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Editor-in-Chief
Journal of International Financial Markets, Institutions and Money

Dear Editor-in-Chief,

Please consider the manuscript entitled “From Apparent Edge to No-Go: A Point-in-Time, Cost-Aware Audit of Heterogeneous XAUUSD Trading Strategies” for publication as a full-length empirical research article in the *Journal of International Financial Markets, Institutions and Money*.

The manuscript addresses a central credibility problem in international-market strategy research: an apparently profitable rule is often reported without carrying the broader specification search through realistic costs, multiplicity control, temporal diagnostics, and independent-feed replication. We audit a locked universe of 39 primary XAUUSD specifications spanning 20 economic families, including price-only technical, event-response, cross-asset, long-horizon momentum, and gold-silver relative-value rules. The design preserves complete negative evidence and separates eight historically selected machine-learning combinations from primary inference.

The results are economically and methodologically informative. Positive average returns decline from 24 specifications before costs to 5 under source-native severe costs and 1 under a common fixed-stress schedule. No specification passes its complete native acceptance gates, no family approaches the within-family max- t threshold, and 7 of 20 eligible specifications fail cross-feed replication. The paper does not claim universal gold-market efficiency. It identifies, under a transparent locked protocol, why apparent edges fail to become statistically and operationally defensible.

The manuscript fits the journal’s coverage of international and foreign-exchange-related financial markets, information and speculation, and empirical market behavior. It also speaks directly to prior articles in the journal on intraday technical trading in precious metals and false-discovery-controlled technical-analysis profitability, while engaging recent evidence on large technical-rule universes, gold-price prediction, volatility forecasting, and the state-dependent investment role of gold.

The submission includes the full and anonymized CAS-format manuscripts, title page, highlights, supplementary material, declarations, figure sources, machine-readable result tables, and an independently audited replication package. No post-2024 outcome entered the consolidated computation. Historical result files were prohibited as runner inputs. All figures are reproducible data visualizations derived from the frozen result tables.

At submission, the corresponding author will confirm that the manuscript is original, is not under consideration elsewhere, and has been approved by all listed authors. The funding, competing-interest, repository, and exclusive-submission statements must be verified before upload.

Thank you for considering this work.

Sincerely,

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